Epilogue

Dearest Rose,

I can't believe it's you. After all this time? Forgive me, but I had almost given up hope of ever hearing from you again. And then Paulette forwarded your letter, and when I saw your handwriting, the decades fell away as though it had all happened yesterday.

It's hard for me to talk about that last day after you got out of the car. Even now, the memories are still raw. The driver, avoiding a roadblock, took a country lane. A man appeared out of nowhere—he shot the driver, and Josef and André. I believe they died instantly and didn't suffer. Three lives over a car. The man spared me and I fled. At least I was able to save Katya, and, as I would learn later, the baby growing inside me, Josef's daughter.

You asked about Katya—she's now a mother with two teenage boys. She's also a professor of modern French history at the Sorbonne. She's a remarkable woman and Nadiya would be proud.

Eve, my daughter with Josef, is a surgeon at Hôpital de la Pitié-Salpêtrière in Paris. She loves her work and has never married—says she doesn't have time for love. Her eyes are the same as her father's. It's truly astonishing.

I won't come to Berlin. I'm happy the wall is being torn down and you now have your freedom. But we can't go back to being the way we were, not after everything that's happened. I don't know why you stayed behind—perhaps it no longer matters. Everyone else has forgotten the war. I want to forget it too. I've spent too much time living in the past.

Léa